Decapitation

Israel claims Larijani killed. Brent back above $102. GTC delivered $1T. FOMC begins. Crypto surges.

MARKETS

MONDAY'S RALLY MEETS TUESDAY'S REALITY. Monday closed strong—S&P +1.01% to 6,699 (SPY $669.03), Dow +0.83%, Nasdaq +1.12%—the broadest green session since before the war. UVXY collapsed 11.88%. Every sector finished positive, led by tech (+1.45%) and discretionary (+1.21%). Oil pulled back sharply as select tankers transited Hormuz over the weekend—USO –4.05%, BNO –2.81%. But Tuesday morning erased the optimism: S&P futures dropped after Israel claimed it killed Ali Larijani, Iran's security chief, and the Basij commander overnight. Brent climbed back above $102. The one-day bounce is being tested within 12 hours.

GTC delivered. Jensen Huang doubled the Blackwell/Vera Rubin order estimate to $1 trillion through 2027—up from $500B last year. Vera Rubin ships later this year with 10x performance per watt over Grace Blackwell. The Groq 3 LPU increases tokens per watt by 35x when paired with Rubin GPUs. NemoClaw—the enterprise-grade agentic AI stack built on OpenClaw—positions Nvidia to own the inference layer, not just training. The semi sleeve responded: LRCX +3.39% ($219.40), KEYS +2.20% ($285.94), ADI +1.58% ($310.92), AMD +1.65% ($196.58), NVDA +1.65% ($183.22), TSM +0.57% ($340.23).

Crypto was the session's real outperformer. ETHA surged 10.82% ($17.61)—its best day since the pre-war period. IBIT +3.89% ($41.94). HUT +5.94% ($51.19), COIN +3.98% ($203.32), HOOD +2.62% ($75.31). BTC is trading near $74,200, up ~8% in March and eyeing its first monthly gain since October. The 14-day negative funding streak ended last week—historically a local bottom signal. Spot bitcoin ETFs have seen ~$1.3B in net inflows in March. Risk assets are bifurcating: crypto catching a sustained bid while equities stall.

The FOMC two-day meeting begins this morning. Decision and dot plot Wednesday at 2 PM ET. CME FedWatch shows 92%+ probability of a hold at 3.50–3.75%. The rate decision itself is irrelevant—the dot plot is the event. If the median shifts to zero cuts for 2026, equities reprice immediately. If it holds at one cut with dovish language acknowledging the energy shock, the rally resumes. Two January dissenters (Miran and Waller) preferred a cut—watch whether that number grows. This is one of Powell's last meetings before Warsh takes over in May.

IOWN Tactical: S&P at 6,699 on Monday's close, pulling back to ~6,672 by Tuesday midday. The 200DMA at ~6,608 held on Friday's test and the bounce was immediate—but a 1% rally into fresh war escalation and the FOMC is not a trend reversal. It's a breather. The next 48 hours decide whether this is an inflection or a dead-cat bounce. Research Reveals Opportunities—the signal hasn't fired yet.

GEOPOLITICS

DAY 18. ISRAEL CLAIMS LARIJANI KILLED—IRAN'S DE FACTO WARTIME LEADER. Ali Larijani—secretary of Iran's Supreme National Security Council, former nuclear negotiator, former parliament speaker—was reportedly killed in an overnight Israeli strike on a Tehran safe house. The IDF also claims it killed Basij paramilitary commander Gholamreza Soleimani. Iran has not confirmed either. If true, Larijani is the highest-profile assassination since the elder Khamenei on Day 1. The decapitation strategy is systematic: the US and Israel are dismantling Iran's command structure layer by layer.

Before the strike, Mojtaba Khamenei had already rejected all ceasefire proposals conveyed by two intermediary countries. A senior Iranian official described his stance as very tough and serious—no peace until the US and Israel accept defeat and pay compensation. Iran continues missile salvoes at Israel and Gulf states. Debris from intercepts killed one in Abu Dhabi, injured two in Kuwait. Dubai International Airport suspended flights again. The Fujairah oil zone took another drone hit. Over 1,300 Iranians have been killed since the war began, according to the Red Crescent. More than 1 million Lebanese displaced as Israel expanded ground operations.

The coalition gambit has failed. EU foreign ministers declined to expand naval operations. Australia and Japan publicly refused to send ships. The UK said it would not be drawn into the wider war. Trump claims unnamed countries are on the way but no one has committed publicly. Gulf oil exports are down 61% versus February—from 25.1M bpd to 9.7M bpd in the week to March 15, per Reuters/Kpler. That is the largest supply disruption in oil market history. Countries are cutting bilateral deals with Tehran instead: India got tankers through, Pakistan's Karachi tanker transited with AIS on, Iraq is negotiating directly, Turkey secured passage last week.

The Hormuz blockade is not absolute—it's selective. Iran is allowing non-Western-aligned shipping through while blocking US and allied vessels. This is creating an alternative trade architecture in real-time: a two-tier global oil market where access depends on your relationship with Tehran, not free navigation. The post-war energy order will look fundamentally different regardless of how this ends.

ON OUR RADAR

1. The dot plot is the week's macro event. Wednesday 2 PM ET. If the median shifts to zero cuts for 2026, the bond market sells and the 200DMA test resumes immediately. If it holds at one cut with language acknowledging the energy supply shock, equities rally. Two January dissenters wanted a cut—watch whether that number grows. This is Powell's second-to-last meeting as chair.

2. The Larijani assassination changes the ceasefire calculus. Killing Iran's top security official could either accelerate capitulation or eliminate a credible negotiating partner. Larijani was a former nuclear negotiator—he knew how to make deals. His removal shrinks the pool of Iranian interlocutors. Markets are repricing accordingly: Monday's de-escalation trade is unwinding Tuesday morning.

3. GTC's $1T demand narrative is structurally bullish for semis. Huang doubled the Blackwell/Vera Rubin order estimate to $1T through 2027. NVDA is guiding $78B this quarter (+77% YoY). LRCX (+3.39%), KEYS (+2.20%), SYK (+3.80%) led our holdings Monday—names down 15–25% from highs getting aggressive buying. The question is whether GTC can provide a multi-day bid or whether oil overwhelms it by Wednesday.

4. Crypto is decoupling from equities. ETHA +10.82% in a single session. IBIT +3.89%. BTC near $74K. Spot ETF inflows positive for the first time since October. The negative funding rate streak just ended—a historically reliable bottom signal. Our digital asset sleeve is the portfolio's best-performing segment this week. Think Like an Owner.

5. Gulf exports down 61% is the number that matters. Reuters/Kpler data: Middle East crude exports averaged 9.7M bpd last week, down from 25.1M bpd in February. That is the largest supply disruption in oil market history. If Hormuz doesn't reopen by mid-April, reserves deplete and Brent goes to $120+. Iran's $200 oil threat is becoming less far-fetched.

6. Bilateral deals are replacing multilateral order. India, Pakistan, Turkey, Iraq—all negotiating separately with Tehran for passage rights. The Hormuz blockade is selective, not absolute. This fracturing of the global oil order is structurally bullish for US energy independence names. CVX ($196.84), VLO ($232.57), CNX ($41.96), OKE ($85.32)—these are the businesses that protect you when the old order breaks. Avoid Erosion.

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